became hyperactive in covering these stories; most often with anti-establishment freelancing journalists based in India.[14] Several Indian journalists like Barkha Dutt even revived their careers tracking ‘on-the-road’ micro stories of the journey home on their YouTube channels.[15] To give you a better idea of why I cautiously use the word ‘revive’, her YouTube channel Mojo Story attracted fewer than 7,000 views in October 2019. After the grotesque coverage of selling miseries and Hindu pyres, the channel began to attract over 2 lakh views per video. Several folks in the film industry made documentaries and several authors wrote books detailing the miseries the migrants faced.[16] [17] Due to this increased coverage, it began to take up lot of prime-time space in news channels, print media as well as social media. As a consequence, success stories of how India was saving most lives per capita as compared to the rest of the world became buried, putting the government on the back foot in terms of media perception. However, despite going all out, these loaded tactics failed to dent the approval ratings of the prime minister.

Let us take for instance, the Bihar Assembly polls, which took place in November 2020—the first state-level elections to follow after the COVID-19 crisis. Prof. Shamika Ravi of Brookings Institution authored a paper with an in-depth post-poll analysis of the results, which were in favour of the prime minister-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government. The paper revealingly concluded that the poorest districts of Bihar, from where most migrants come from, voted for the BJP. The paper also made the scientific assumption that the post-COVID schemes announced by the prime minister were truly reaching the last Indian on the ground, a significant chunk of who were migrant returnees in Bihar, as intended. This analysis also discredits the jingoism fed into the media by the political opposition about the migrants being angry, ignored and unhappy with the Modi government.[18]

Now, coming back to the Mumbai episode with an understanding of the prevalent media narrative of the time, there were several pertinent questions to be asked. Could one draw a conclusion that the Shiv Sena-led government wanted to instigate and create an episode displaying migrant desperation which would continue to push the anti-government media narrative? Were the cops asked to deliberately ignore the crowds walking to the railway station? Was any investigation conducted to find out if the